

- : WORKSHOP OVERVIEW : -

Workshop on Essentials for Mortality Investigation of Asian Elephant

Chhattisgarh Forest Department · Bilaspur Circle

In Technical Partnership with Wildlife Institute of India & ICAR-IVRI

05 – 06 June 2026 · Raigarh, Chhattisgarh

2

Days

18

Sessions

5

National
Experts

30+

Participants

48

Elephant
Deaths Analyzed



Inaugural session — Workshop on Mortality Investigation of Asian Elephant, Raigarh, June 2026.

The **Workshop on Essentials for Mortality Investigation of Asian Elephant** was organized by the Chhattisgarh Forest Department, Bilaspur Circle, through the special initiative of **Hon'ble Forest Minister Shri Kedar Kashyap**, in technical partnership with the **Wildlife Institute of India**, Dehradun, and **ICAR-IVRI**, Bareilly. Held on 05–06 June 2026 at Raigarh, Chhattisgarh, the two-day workshop brought together five nationally eminent experts to equip field officers with systematic, evidence-based skills for elephant mortality investigation.



- : Organizing Team : -

Shri Kedar Kashyap

Hon'ble Forest Minister

Department of Forest & Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh

Shri Arun Kumar Pandey, IFS

Principal Chief Conservator of Forests & Head of Forest Force

Department of Forest & Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh

Senior Officers

Shri Matheshwaran V., IFS

APCCF Wildlife

CG Forest Dept.

Shri Manoj Kumar Pandey, IFS

CCF, Bilaspur Circle

CG Forest Dept.

Smt. Priyanka Pandey, IFS

CCF Wildlife Bilaspur
& Field Director ATR
CG Forest Dept.

Technical Partners

Wildlife Institute of India (WII), Dehradun — India's premier institution for wildlife research and training, contributing expertise in wildlife health management, chemical capture, and wildlife forensic science.

ICAR–Indian Veterinary Research Institute (IVRI), Bareilly — National centre for veterinary pathology, wildlife disease diagnosis, and health surveillance, contributing expertise in necropsy, molecular diagnostics, and sampling protocols.

Nanaji Deshmukh Veterinary Science University (NDVSU), Jabalpur — Contributing expertise in wildlife forensics and health management drawn from three decades of field experience across Central India.

Resource Persons

01 Dr. Parag Nigam

Session Chair

Senior Scientist & Head, Wildlife Health Management

Wildlife Institute of India, Dehradun

02 Dr. A. B. Shrivastav

Resource Person

Former Director, Centre for Wildlife Forensic & Health; Professor & Veterinary Pathologist

NDVSU, Jabalpur

03 Dr. Karikalan Mathesh

Resource Person

Senior Scientist, Centre for Wildlife Conservation, Management & Disease Surveillance

ICAR-IVRI, Bareilly

04 Dr. Chandra Prakash Sharma

Resource Person

Principal Technical Officer & In-charge, Morphology Unit, WFCGC

- : Speaker Statements : -

DA

"Every elephant death is a data point — if we investigate systematically, the forest tells us exactly what we need to know to prevent the next one."

– Dr. A. B. Shrivastav

DP

"Systematic necropsy is not just a scientific procedure; it is an act of accountability to the elephant, to the ecosystem, and to the communities that share this landscape."

– Dr. Parag Nigam

DK

"EEHV is a silent predator. Without PCR diagnostics reaching the ground level, we remain blind to the most lethal infectious threat young elephants face today."

– Dr. Karikalan Mathesh

DC

"Evidence collected poorly is evidence lost forever. Forensic discipline at the mortality site determines the outcome of every investigation — and every court proceeding."

– Dr. Chandra Prakash Sharma

DT

"Every tissue sample we preserve today is a resource for tomorrow's conservation science. The necropsy table is where field work meets molecular genetics."

– Dr. Tapendra Saini

■ ■ Workshop Background

Chhattisgarh has emerged as one of India's most significant elephant habitats, with the Bilaspur Circle — encompassing the Dharamjaigarh and Raigarh Van Mandals — hosting the state's highest concentration of wild elephants. The elephant population has grown remarkably, from an estimated 24 individuals in 2001 to approximately 450 elephants in 2026, reflecting nearly 10% compound annual growth. These elephants inhabit forest areas across the Surguja, Bilaspur, Raipur, and Durg divisions. This rapid expansion has intensified the human-elephant interface and, critically, raised the toll of elephant mortalities to a level demanding systematic institutional response.

Between 2021–22 and 2026–27, a total of 48 elephant deaths were recorded across Dharamjaigarh (27 deaths) and Raigarh (21 deaths) Van Mandals. Electrocution (51%) and drowning (22%) account for the majority. The 2025–26 season recorded the highest single-year toll, with 2026–27 already showing a disturbing pattern of calf drowning deaths in the early months of the year.

— Chhattisgarh Forest Department Data, 2021–2026

In view of the incidents of elephant calf deaths in the Raigarh and Dharamjaigarh Forest Divisions, and to understand the causes of such deaths, a national-level workshop was organized on 05–06 June 2026 in Raigarh district through the special initiative of **Hon'ble Forest Minister Shri Kedar Kashyap**. The Department of Forest & Climate Change is working to bring human-elephant conflict to zero, with positive results already witnessed in the field.

■ ■ Workshop Objectives

- To train field officers in systematic and scientific investigation of elephant mortalities, covering veterinary, forensic, and legal dimensions.
- To standardize necropsy procedures, sampling protocols, and mortality documentation practices for the Dharamjaigarh and Raigarh Van Mandals.
- To equip officers with the knowledge to identify major causes of elephant death — electrocution, drowning, infectious diseases, and poisoning — and implement targeted preventive measures.

■ ■ Participants

- **Chhattisgarh Forest Department:** Range Officers, Beat Guards, and Wildlife Wardens from Dharamjaigarh and Raigarh Van Mandals, and officers from elephant-affected districts.
- **Animal Resources Department, Chhattisgarh:** Veterinary officers from elephant-affected districts of the state.
- **National Technical Experts:** Veterinarians, scientists, and elephant specialists from Wildlife Institute of India, ICAR-IVRI, and NDVSU Jabalpur.

Inaugural Session

05 June 2026 · 10:00 – 11:00 hrs · Raigarh, Chhattisgarh

Shri Kedar Kashyap

Hon'ble Forest Minister — Inaugural Address

Department of Forest & Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh

The workshop was formally inaugurated by **Hon'ble Forest Minister Shri Kedar Kashyap**, whose special initiative drove the organization of this national-level event in response to the recent incidents of elephant calf deaths in the Raigarh and Dharamjaigarh Forest Divisions. In his inaugural address, the Hon'ble Minister spoke directly to the significance of this workshop — both as a conservation imperative and as a commitment to the communities living alongside Chhattisgarh's growing elephant population.

Full Address — Hon'ble Forest Minister Shri Kedar Kashyap

The elephant population in Chhattisgarh has been growing continuously over the past five years, and currently approximately 450 elephants are present in the state. These elephants are permanently inhabiting the forest areas of Surguja, Bilaspur, Raipur, and Durg divisions. The Department of Forest and Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh, is continuously working for the conservation, enhancement, and protection of these elephants while also ensuring the safety of local communities. Under the direction of the Hon'ble Forest Minister, the department is striving to bring human-elephant conflict to zero — and positive outcomes have already been achieved.

Keeping in mind the recent incidents of elephant calf deaths in the Raigarh and Dharamjaigarh Forest Divisions of Raigarh district, and in order to investigate the causes of these deaths, a national-level workshop has been organised on 5–6 June 2026 in Raigarh district through the special initiative of Hon'ble Forest Minister Shri Kedar Kashyap. This workshop brings together national-level veterinarians, scientists, and elephant experts alongside state veterinarians and officers of the Department of Forest & Climate Change and the Animal Resources Department from all elephant-affected districts of Chhattisgarh.

The objective of the workshop is to scientifically investigate the causes of wild elephant deaths and to prepare management strategies for the future. Participants will receive practical training in examining dead elephants, collecting biological samples, and dispatching them safely to laboratories. In addition, the workshop will strengthen safety protocols for carcass handling, procedures for proper carcass disposal, and overall preparedness for elephant mortality incidents and health surveillance systems across the state.

■ ■ Address by PCCF & Head of Forest Force

Shri Arun Kumar Pandey, IFS

Principal Chief Conservator of Forests & Head of Forest Force

Department of Forest & Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh

Shri Arun Kumar Pandey, IFS, Principal Chief Conservator of Forests and Head of Forest Force, Chhattisgarh, addressed the workshop with a comprehensive overview of the state's elephant conservation efforts and the critical institutional context that made this workshop necessary and timely.

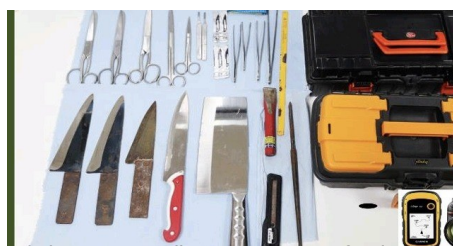
Shri Pandey outlined the remarkable growth of Chhattisgarh's elephant population — from 24 individuals in 2001 to approximately 450 today — as a testament to the department's sustained conservation work over two decades. He acknowledged, however, that this population growth also brought new and complex challenges: increasing human-elephant conflict, expanding corridor pressure, and, most urgently, a rising toll of elephant deaths that demanded systematic investigation.

He emphasized that the Chhattisgarh Forest Department, under the direction of Hon'ble Forest Minister Shri Kedar Kashyap, is committed to understanding the precise causes of every elephant death — particularly the recent incidents of calf mortality in the Raigarh and Dharamjaigarh Van Mandals. He expressed that bringing national-level expertise from WII, ICAR-IVRI, and NDVSU to the field — rather than sending samples to distant laboratories without trained local personnel — represented a fundamental shift in the department's approach to wildlife health management.

The strength of our forest department lies in its field officers. This workshop will give them the scientific tools to do their duty with the precision and accountability that these magnificent animals — and the communities living with them — deserve.

— Shri Arun Kumar Pandey, IFS, PCCF & HoFF

Shri Pandey called upon all participants to engage actively in both the theoretical and practical sessions, and to carry the learning back to their divisions with the commitment to establish standardized investigation protocols. He assured the resource persons of the department's full support in implementing the workshop's recommendations and developing a formal SOP for elephant mortality investigation in Chhattisgarh.



Inaugural ceremony — Workshop on Mortality Investigation of Asian Elephant, Raigarh, June 2026.

■ ■ Addresses by Senior Officers

Shri Matheshwaran V., IFS

Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (Wildlife)

Department of Forest & Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh

Shri Matheshwaran V., APCCF Wildlife, addressed the gathering from the perspective of wildlife management across the state. He highlighted that the elephant mortality challenge in Chhattisgarh is inseparable from the broader question of wildlife corridor management and human-wildlife coexistence. He emphasized the critical role of systematic mortality investigation in building an evidence base that directly informs policy and management interventions. He expressed the Wildlife Wing's commitment to institutionalizing the protocols developed through this workshop and extending the training to other elephant-affected divisions across the state.

Shri Manoj Kumar Pandey, IFS

Chief Conservator of Forests, Bilaspur Circle

Department of Forest & Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh

As the hosting officer for the workshop, Shri Manoj Kumar Pandey, CCF Bilaspur Circle, welcomed all resource persons, participants, and senior officers. He placed the workshop in the immediate operational context of the Bilaspur Circle, where the Dharamjaigarh and Raigarh Van Mandals have recorded 48 elephant deaths over the past five years. He acknowledged that while the Circle's field officers are dedicated and experienced, the specialized knowledge required for systematic elephant mortality investigation — particularly in disease diagnosis, forensic documentation, and sample chain-of-custody — had long been a gap that this workshop was specifically designed to address. He expressed gratitude to the Hon'ble Minister and PCCF for their initiative and support in organizing this event.

Smt. Priyanka Pandey, IFS

CCF Wildlife, Bilaspur & Field Director, Achanakmar Tiger Reserve

Department of Forest & Climate Change, Government of Chhattisgarh

Smt. Priyanka Pandey, CCF Wildlife Bilaspur and Field Director of the Achanakmar Tiger Reserve, brought a unique perspective to the inaugural session, highlighting the intersection of elephant mortality investigation with tiger reserve management. She emphasized that the movement of elephants through the ATR landscape made robust mortality investigation protocols essential not just for elephant conservation, but also for the integrity of tiger reserve management. She welcomed the national faculty and expressed confidence that the two-day workshop would lay the foundation for a new standard of scientific rigour in wildlife mortality investigation across Chhattisgarh's protected area network.



Inaugural session with senior officers and resource persons, Raigarh, 05 June 2026.

■ ■ Inaugural Remarks by Resource Persons

Dr. Parag Nigam — Senior Scientist & Head, Wildlife Health Management, WII

Dr. Nigam, in his inaugural remarks, underscored the urgent need for evidence-based investigation of wildlife mortalities. Drawing from nearly three decades of field experience — including India's first tiger reintroduction at Sariska and landmark Indian Gaur reintroductions — he spoke to the critical importance of systematic field necropsy as the cornerstone of wildlife conservation medicine. He commended the Chhattisgarh Forest Department for its proactive approach and expressed that the WII–ICAR–IVRI partnership for this workshop represented a model of institutional collaboration that could be replicated across other states facing similar challenges.

Dr. A. B. Shrivastav — Former Director, Centre for Wildlife Forensic & Health, NDVSU

Prof. Shrivastav addressed the gathering with particular insight into the One Health dimension of elephant mortalities. He emphasized that diseases transmissible between elephants, livestock, and humans — particularly tuberculosis and anthrax — make systematic mortality investigation a public health imperative, not merely a wildlife conservation concern. He called for the workshop's outcomes to be converted into a formal State-level Standard Operating Procedure, backed by departmental order.

Dr. Karikalan Mathesh — Senior Scientist, ICAR–IVRI, Bareilly

Dr. Karikalan spoke on the diagnostic laboratory's perspective on field-collected samples. He emphasized that the quality of samples received from field mortality sites determines what can and cannot be diagnosed — and that poor sample collection is the single most common reason why causes of death remain undetermined. He expressed that equipping Chhattisgarh's field officers with proper sampling knowledge would directly improve the diagnostic yield from every future mortality case referred to ICAR–IVRI.

Dr. Chandra Prakash Sharma — Principal Technical Officer, WII

Dr. Sharma brought the forensic scientist's perspective to the inaugural session. He noted that in his decades of work supporting enforcement agencies across India, the most common weakness in wildlife mortality cases reaching courts was inadequate field documentation. He expressed confidence that the forensic and legal sessions of the workshop would address this gap directly, equipping officers to build cases that could survive legal scrutiny.

This workshop is not just about learning what to do — it is about learning what the law requires of you. Every forest officer at a mortality site is simultaneously a scientist, a custodian of evidence, and an officer of the law.

— Dr. Chandra Prakash Sharma, Wildlife Institute of India

■ ■ Workshop Programme

Two-Day Programme · 05–06 June 2026 · Raigarh, Chhattisgarh · 18 Sessions

Day 1 · 05 June 2026 · 10:00 – 17:30

10:00 11:00	Inauguration Official opening, address by Forest Minister, PCCF & HoFF, senior officers, and resource persons.	Forest Minister · PCCF · Senior Officers
11:00 11:30	Elephant Status & Human-Elephant Interface in Chhattisgarh Population dynamics, corridor use, conflict and mortality trends.	CG Forest Dept.
11:30 12:15	Biological & Anatomical Aspects of Elephants Key anatomical peculiarities relevant to field investigation.	Dr. P. Nigam
12:15 13:00	Understanding Wildlife Mortalities: The Veterinary Perspective Carcass condition, natural vs unnatural death; ante/post-mortem changes & time of death.	Dr. P. Nigam
— Lunch Break: 13:00 – 14:00 —		
14:00 15:30	Infectious Causes of Mortality in Elephants EEHV, EMC, FMD, Rabies, TB, Anthrax, Haemorrhagic Septicaemia.	Dr. K. Mathesh, Dr. Shrivastav
15:30 16:30	Non-Infectious & Disaster Mortalities Electrocution, lightning, train hits, infighting, natural disaster deaths.	Dr. Shrivastav, Dr. K. Mathesh
16:30 17:30	Non-Infectious Diseases in Elephants Mycotoxicosis, kodo millet poisoning, and environmental bio-toxins.	Dr. K. Mathesh, Dr. P. Nigam

Day 2 · 06 June 2026 · 09:30 – 17:30

09:30 10:15	Biosafety & Biosecurity at Elephant Mortality Sites Zoonotic risks, PPE requirements, safe carcass disposal, site sanitation.	Dr. K. Mathesh, Dr. Saini, Dr. Nigam
10:15 11:00	Equipment Familiarization & Site Preparation Chain saws, axes, winches; establishing a secure investigation perimeter.	Dr. Shrivastav, Dr. K. Mathesh, Dr. Saini
— Tea Break & Equipment Demonstration: 11:00 – 11:30 —		
11:30 12:30	Comprehensive Sampling Protocols Collection, packaging, cold chain, transport & documentation for lab analysis.	Dr. K. Mathesh, Dr. Shrivastav, Dr. Saini
12:30 13:00	Recording Information During Necropsy Report writing and photographic documentation standards.	Dr. K. Mathesh, Dr. Shrivastav
— Lunch Break: 13:00 – 14:00 —		
14:00 14:45	Vetro-Legal & Forensic Aspects of Mortality Investigation Investigation essentials for legal and forensic frameworks.	Dr. C.P. Sharma
14:45 16:00	Practical: Crime Scene Investigation Chain of custody, evidence collection, legal procedures for ivory/tusk extraction.	Dr. C.P. Sharma, Dr. Nigam, Dr. Saini
16:15 16:45	Panel Discussion Critical aspects of managing mortalities in elephants.	All Faculty & CG Officers
16:45 17:30	Valedictory Workshop recap, feedback collection, and closing ceremony.	—

■ ■ Session Highlights · Day 1 · 05 June 2026

● Elephant Status & Human-Elephant Interface in Chhattisgarh

The opening technical session presented a comprehensive overview of elephant population dynamics in the Bilaspur Circle. Data revealed a growth trajectory from 24 elephants in 2001 to approximately 450 by 2026, with the Dharamjaigarh and Raigarh Van Mandals as the primary habitat zone. Year-wise mortality data showing 48 deaths over five years was presented, with electrocution (51%) and drowning (22%) as dominant causes. The intensification of conflict as agricultural expansion encroaches on corridors was identified as the central management challenge.

● Biological & Anatomical Aspects of Elephants

Dr. Parag Nigam delivered an engaging session on the unique anatomy and physiology of Asian elephants relevant to field investigation — including foot structure, dental formula and tusk anatomy, organ positions, and why elephant necropsy requires specialized equipment and a coordinated multi-person team. Officers learned to identify anatomical landmarks that guide incision sequences during post-mortem examination.

● Understanding Wildlife Mortalities: The Veterinary Perspective

This session introduced the fundamental framework for classifying wildlife deaths — natural versus unnatural, acute versus chronic. Dr. Nigam covered ante-mortem and post-mortem changes in detail, helping officers understand how ambient temperature, sun exposure, and time since death alter the carcass. The session was particularly valued by officers who routinely encounter carcasses in advanced decomposition.

● Infectious Causes of Mortality in Elephants

Co-delivered by Dr. Karikalan Mathesh and Dr. A.B. Shrivastav, this session provided a systematic review of infectious diseases known to cause elephant mortality. EEHV received particular attention, with the critical role of whole blood PCR emphasized. FMD, Rabies, Tuberculosis, Anthrax, and Haemorrhagic Septicaemia were also covered, with participants equipped to recognize field signs and gross pathological changes indicative of each disease.

● Non-Infectious & Disaster Mortalities

Dr. Shrivastav presented a systematic framework for distinguishing electrocution deaths from other causes — characteristic lesions (entry/exit burns, supra-orbital lesions, internal haemorrhages) and the investigative report's role in triggering action against illegal power lines. Lightning strikes, train collisions, drowning, and infighting deaths were also covered with emphasis on distinguishing pathological features.

● Non-Infectious Diseases in Elephants

The final Day 1 session addressed toxicological causes — a critically under-investigated category in the Indian context. Dr. Karikalan presented detailed information on mycotoxicosis, with particular attention to kodo millet toxicity (a documented cause of elephant deaths in central India), and reviewed environmental bio-toxins. Officers received a framework for considering toxicological causes when initial investigation reveals no clear evidence of trauma, infectious disease, or natural illness.

■ ■ Session Highlights · Day 2 · 06 June 2026

● Biosafety & Biosecurity at Elephant Mortality Sites

Day 2 opened with a critical session on the biosafety risks associated with elephant carcasses. Dr. Karikalan outlined the spectrum of zoonotic risks — from anthrax and tuberculosis to other pathogens transmissible through carcass contact — and the standard PPE requirements for all personnel. The session covered safe carcass disposal, site decontamination protocols, and biosecurity measures required when infectious disease is suspected.

● Equipment Familiarization & Site Preparation

A hands-on session focused on the practical challenges of elephant necropsy under field conditions. Participants were introduced to heavy-duty equipment required — chain saws, axes, winches, block-and-tackle systems — and the sequence for their use. The critical importance of establishing a secure investigation perimeter and documenting the site before any physical intervention was emphasized.

● Comprehensive Sampling Protocols

This session addressed one of the most critical gaps in current practice: collection, preservation, and transport of biological samples from elephant carcasses. The full spectrum of sample types was covered — fresh tissue for histopathology, blood for virology, swabs for bacteriology, rumen contents for toxicology. Participants received detailed instruction on container types, preservation media, cold chain requirements, and documentation standards required for ICAR-IVRI's diagnostic laboratory.

● Recording Information During Necropsy

Dr. Karikalan and Dr. Shrivastav covered systematic documentation requirements for a complete necropsy record — including carcass condition scoring, gross pathological findings by organ system, preliminary cause-of-death assessment, and sample inventory. Guidance was provided on the specific photographs required at each stage to create a complete visual record admissible as evidence in legal proceedings.

● Vetro-Legal & Forensic Aspects of Mortality Investigation

Dr. Chandra Prakash Sharma delivered this pivotal session on legal and forensic dimensions of mortality investigation: chain-of-custody protocols, the legal framework for ivory/tusk custody under the Wildlife Protection Act, and forensic report standards that withstand court scrutiny. Participants gained clarity on their legal obligations at a mortality site and procedures for coordinating with police and revenue authorities.

● Practical: Crime Scene Investigation & Panel Discussion

Dr. Sharma led participants through a simulated crime scene investigation covering evidence marking, photography, chain-of-custody documentation, and evidence packaging. Officers practiced ivory/tusk extraction procedures and the documentation sequence that creates a legally defensible investigation record. The subsequent Panel Discussion addressed specific operational challenges raised by field officers — from accessing remote mortality sites to multi-agency coordination protocols.

■ ■ Key Outcomes & Recommendations

The two-day workshop generated concrete outcomes and forward-looking recommendations reflecting the consensus of national experts and field officers from both Van Mandals.

■ ■ Key Outcomes

- Thirty-plus field officers from Dharamjaigarh and Raigarh Van Mandals and officers from elephant-affected districts trained in systematic elephant mortality investigation.
- A standardized **Field Necropsy Checklist** and **Sample Collection Protocol** developed and distributed to all participants, adapted for Chhattisgarh's field conditions.
- Consensus reached on a **Minimum Evidence Standard** for elephant mortality investigation reports — covering carcass documentation, sample inventory, photographic record, and preliminary cause-of-death assessment.
- Strengthened institutional relationships between the Chhattisgarh Forest Department, WII, ICAR-IVRI, and NDVSU for ongoing technical support and diagnostic laboratory access.
- A framework for a **dedicated Elephant Mortality Investigation Cell** within the Bilaspur Circle proposed, with defined roles, equipment requirements, and referral pathways.

■ ■ Recommendations

Standard Operating Procedure

The Chhattisgarh Forest Department should develop and circulate a formal departmental SOP for elephant mortality investigation, drawing on the protocols shared during the workshop and adapted to the specific terrain, resources, and legal context of the state.

Dedicated Mortality Investigation Team

Each Van Mandal should designate a core team of trained officers — including at least one Range Officer with necropsy training — as the first-response unit for elephant mortality sites, with a pre-staged equipment kit maintained at division level.

Laboratory Linkage with ICAR-IVRI

A formal sample referral arrangement with ICAR-IVRI, Bareilly, should be established to ensure that biological samples from elephant mortalities receive priority processing and systematic diagnostic reporting back to the field department.

Annual Refresher Training

Given the complexity of elephant mortality investigation and the regular turnover of field staff, an annual refresher training programme is strongly recommended — potentially co-facilitated by trained Chhattisgarh Forest Department officers.

Electrocution Prevention as Priority

With electrocution accounting for 51% of elephant deaths in the study period, the workshop strongly endorses prioritizing identification and removal of illegal and low-hung power lines as the single most impactful intervention available.

■ ■ Valedictory Session

06 June 2026 · 16:45 – 17:30 hrs · Raigarh, Chhattisgarh

The valedictory session brought the two-day workshop to a formal and reflective close. Presided over by the CCF, Bilaspur Circle, and attended by all senior officers and resource persons, the session provided an opportunity for participants and faculty to reflect on the learning journey of the preceding two days.

■ ■ Participant Reflections

Selected field officers from both Van Mandals shared their key learnings. Recurring themes included: the transformative clarity gained on the necropsy procedure and its legal significance; new appreciation for the forensic value of initial site documentation; and the confidence gained from understanding disease frameworks — particularly around EEHV, electrocution lesions, and toxicological causes. Several officers expressed that the practical crime scene investigation exercise was among the most valuable sessions of their careers.

■ ■ Closing Remarks by Faculty

Dr. A. B. Shrivastav expressed that the quality of engagement from Chhattisgarh's field officers was exceptional. He recommended that future editions include a live necropsy demonstration and called for the workshop to become an annual event. Dr. Parag Nigam emphasized that the most important next step was institutional — converting the workshop's learning into formal departmental protocols. He offered WII's ongoing technical support for the development of a Chhattisgarh SOP and for future training iterations.

■ ■ Closing Address

The closing address by Shri Manoj Kumar Pandey, CCF Bilaspur Circle, highlighted the significance of the workshop in Chhattisgarh's elephant conservation trajectory. He expressed gratitude to Hon'ble Forest Minister Shri Kedar Kashyap for his vision in initiating this workshop, to PCCF Shri Arun Kumar Pandey for his leadership, and to all five resource persons for their dedicated engagement over two intensive days.

What we have built in these two days is not just knowledge — it is the foundation of a system. The 48 elephant deaths we have analyzed here must be the last generation that go uninvestigated. From this workshop forward, every death in our forests will be accounted for.

— Closing Address, Valedictory Session, 06 June 2026

Participation certificates were presented to all field officers by the senior faculty and departmental officers. A group photograph of all participants and faculty was taken in closing. The workshop formally concluded at 17:30 hrs on 06 June 2026.